

INDIVIDUAL TAX PREPARATION

Preparing for Tax Season

A practical checklist for organizing common records, identifying gaps, and arriving better prepared for a tax-preparation conversation.

PART 01 / BUILD THE FILE

Create a clear starting point before documents begin to pile up.

SET UP THE SYSTEM

- ☐ Create one secure folder for the current tax year.
- ☐ Keep personal and business records separate where applicable.
- ☐ Use clear filenames that include the document type and year.
- ☐ Review the prior-year return for carryforwards or recurring records.

GATHER COMMON INCOME RECORDS

- ☐ Wage, retirement, benefit, or other income statements received.
- ☐ Interest, dividend, investment, or platform income records where applicable.
- ☐ Self-employment or other business income summaries where applicable.
- ☐ Records for any other income that may need to be discussed.

GATHER SUPPORTING RECORDS

- ☐ Potential deduction or credit documentation where applicable.
- ☐ Estimated tax payment confirmations.
- ☐ Relevant state or local tax records.
- ☐ Documentation of major family, financial, property, or business changes.

A SIMPLE PREPARATION TIMELINE

- As documents arrive: file and label them.
- Before the appointment: compare records with your expected-document list.
- During preparation: keep a running list of questions and missing items.
- After filing: retain the final return and supporting records securely.

PART 02 / RESOLVE THE GAPS

Know what is missing, what changed, and what you need to ask.

WHEN SOMETHING IS MISSING

- ☐ Do not estimate or recreate an official form from memory.
- ☐ Contact the issuer and request a replacement or corrected document.
- ☐ Track each missing item, the date requested, and its status.
- ☐ Ask whether preparation should wait until the missing record arrives.

FINAL READINESS CHECK

- ☐ Contact information is current.
- ☐ Expected documents have been checked against what was received.
- ☐ Questions and missing items are written down.
- ☐ Sensitive records are ready to share through an approved secure method.

QUESTIONS TO PREPARE

- ☐ What changed since the prior tax year?
- ☐ Are there unfamiliar documents or transactions to explain?
- ☐ Are any records incomplete, corrected, or still expected?
- ☐ What should be organized differently for next year?

NOTES / QUESTIONS

This guide supports general organization and filing readiness. It is not individualized tax advice and does not promise or guarantee any tax outcome.